

Best Yoga Poses for Ankylosing Spondylitis Stiffness

Practical NHS-backed advice on best yoga poses for ankylosing spondylitis stiffness.

By **Living With Arthritis UK** · Reviewed by **Louis Maxwell** (HCPC Registered Physiotherapist) · 2026-07-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

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Quick Answer: The best yoga poses for ankylosing spondylitis (AS) stiffness focus on spinal extension, hip flexibility, and breathing exercises: Cat-Cow, Child's Pose, Cobra, Standing Mountain Pose, and seated twists. These counter AS's tendency to cause forward-flexed posture and rib cage stiffness. Always practise gently within comfortable range.

AS causes inflammation and stiffness primarily in the spine and sacroiliac joints. Without regular movement, the spine can gradually fuse in a flexed position. Yoga — particularly spinal extension and breathing practices — is strongly recommended by NASS as part of daily AS management.

Morning Stiffness Sequence

Core Poses

- Cat-Cow stretch: On hands and knees, alternate arching and rounding the back. 10 slow repetitions — best way to mobilise a stiff spine first thing
- Child's Pose: Kneel and reach arms forward, resting forehead down. Hold 30 seconds
- Cobra Pose: Lie face down, press up through arms to extend spine. Counters AS's flexion tendency — 3 holds of 15 seconds
- Lying knee rotations: Lie on back, slowly lower both knees side to side. 10 each side

Breathing for Chest Expansion

- Deep diaphragmatic breathing — AS can affect rib joints limiting breathing
 - Prone (face down) breathing — 5 minutes daily significantly improves chest expansion
 - Seated arm raises on inhale — opens the chest as you breathe in
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What to Avoid



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Avoid extreme forward flexion (deep forward folds that round the spine) — this reinforces AS posture. Never force movement during a flare — switch to breathing exercises and rest positions only.

Q&A;

Question: Is yoga safe during an AS flare? **Short answer:** During an active flare, stick only to gentle breathing exercises and minimal movement. Consult your physiotherapist or rheumatologist if unsure.

Question: How often should I do yoga with AS? **Short answer:** Daily is ideal — even 10–15 minutes of gentle morning movement makes a significant difference to AS stiffness. NASS recommends daily exercise as a core treatment.

Question: Should I tell the yoga instructor I have AS? **Short answer:** Always inform your instructor before class. Consider an AS-specific class or physiotherapy-led yoga if available in your area.

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